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Presented to Viacheslav Vsevolodovich Ivanov
on the Occasion of His Seventieth Birthday

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LATIN **OPIŌ* AND *OPTĀRE*

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1. It has long been assumed that Lat. *optāre* 'choose, wish' is a frequentative formation based on a form **opto-*, or conceivably **opeto-* (which, with syncope, would again yield **opto-*); both forms would be perf. participles of a verb no longer attested directly in Latin, as in several other cases of this sort (e. g. *nictāre, gustāre, cūnctārī*; Leumann 1977: 547 and García-Hernández 1985: 233, with further references). Likewise pointing to participial **op(e)to-* is its apparent verbal noun *optiō* f. 'choice' (relexicalized as a masculine term of office, in the meaning 'adjutant, assistant'), with a comparable *ti*-stem in Oscan (g. sg. **ufteis** [Ve 6.7] 'voluntatis', nom. pl. **uhftis** [Ve 5C.11] 'voluntates'). Standard doctrine also holds that a trace of the base verb in question appears in a Latin verb **opiō*, **opere* extracted *ex coniectura* from the gloss *praedotiont* 'praeoptant' (Fest. 222.24 L, so printed by both Lindsay and Mueller, the latter with crux), traditionally emended to *praedopiont*, and found among a series of fragments thought to belong to the ancient Carmen Saliare (Morel[3] 4.4, p. 5).[1]

2. Apart from problems associated with the gloss itself (taken up in § 4. below), this account can be questioned on morphological and (inner-Italic) comparative grounds.

2.1. To begin with, *o*-grade (as opposed to zero grade) is entirely unexpected for a primary *je/o*-verb, and calls for some explanation. The sole exception otherwise, i. e. Lat. *fodīre* 'dig', has a natural accounting on the basis of a primary *o*-grade present in Indo-European (cf. Hitt. *padda-* 'id.', OCS *bodǫ* 'stab', and even within Latin the primary thematic present attested in the relic-form *fodentes* [Enn. *Ann.* 526 Sk]), however this formation is to be explained in Indo-European terms (see e. g. Jasanoff 1994: 158ff., LIV 51f.).

2.2. Secondly, although the participial pre-form **opeto-* matches one possible phonological interpretation of comparable Umbrian participial forms (**upetu** 'optatum' IIb 8, 11 and III 22, 26, *upeter* 'optati' Vb 9, 14, both from **opeto-* or **opēto-*),[2] these forms belong with what is clearly an *ē*-verb in Umbrian (cf. 3 sg. imperat. **upetu** IIb 1, 3 pl. **upetuta** III 10), which fails to match the alleged Lat. *je/o*-verb **opiō*. Given

the attractive root etymology of Lat. *optāre* (and its Osco-Umbrian cognates) in terms of PIE *$*h_1ep$-* 'take' (Hitt. *ēpzi*, Lat. *coēpī*, etc.),[3] an *o*-grade *ē*-verb *$*opēi̯e/o$-*, ptcple. **opeto-* (in Italic terms) could simply reflect an IE iterative *$*h_1op$-éi̯e/o-*, which would provide a straightforward morphological account of both the *o*-grade and the *ē*-inflection.[4]

2.3. Moreover, in terms of regular patterns of Latin derivational morphology, there is no need of a formation like **opiō* (as opposed to various other infectum types) to account for Lat. *optāre*. It is well-established that the perfectum stems of many Latin verbs are formed on the basis of their corresponding infectum stems,[5] and the process is certainly found with *ē*-verbs.[6] Thus a (pre-) Lat. **opto-* (one direct source of *optāre*, cf. § 1. above) could have arisen directly from an *ē*-verb infectum **opē-*, as in **dokto-* ← **dokē-* and other such cases.

3. Given the possibility that PIE *$*h_1ep$-* was originally inflected as an acrostatic ("Narten") present (3 sg. *$*h_1ép$-ti*, pl. *$*h_1ép$-n̥ti*),[7] one could perhaps salvage a Lat. <**opiō*> by reinterpreting the form as **ōpiō*, since this would correspond to an "ideal" Narten-present iterative(-causative), of the type *$*su̯ép$-i̯e/o-* (> Lat. *sōpiō*, ON *sœfa* 'put to sleep'; Klingenschmitt 1978). But this sort of reinterpretation must face the following objections and qualifications:

3.1. First and foremost, there is no direct evidence favoring a long vowel in Lat. <*opt-*>, such as inscriptional apex or geminatio vocalium.[8] Since the regular application of Latin vowel-weakening to a stem *ŏpt-* might be expected to result in compounds like ***exuptāre*, ***aduptāre* etc.,[9] one may be tempted to invoke the actually-attested <*exoptāre, adoptāre*> etc. as evidence favoring /ōpt-/. In fact, however, the treatment /oCC/ > /X-uCC-/ seems to be unknown to Latin verbal derivation (thus *indoctus* 'uninstructed' to *doceō* 'teach', not ***inductus*; *dēspondēre* 'pledge', not ***dēspundēre*), and is regularly controverted in nominal derivation as well (e. g. *īnfrōns*, gen. *īnfrondis* [not **/-frund-/] 'leafless', to *frōns* 'foliage'; *dupondius* 'coin worth two as-pieces', cf. Lucil. *dupundī* [n. 9]). There is, then, no obstacle to the more likely explanation that forms like *exoptāre* simply have their root vocalism restored by recomposition, precisely as in cases like *indoctus*, *dēspondēre*, *īnfrond-*, *dupondius*, and a number of others.

3.2. Direct evidence favoring /opt-/ (vs. /ōpt-/) can be found in the standard spelling *ὀπτ-* for forms of Lat. *optiō* 'adjutant', well-attested in Greek inscriptions and papyri (see TLL IX².823.4ff.), and in Greek authors (ibid. 44ff.: Plutarch, Lydus, Procopius).

3.3. Given the Narten-causative Lat. *sōpīre* (cf. above), with perf. ptcple. *sōpītus*, a Narten-iterative **ōpīre* would be expected to show a perf. ptcple. **ōpītus*, whence a predicted frequentative **ōpītāre*, not **ōptāre* (cf. *dormītāre* 'be drowsy' to *dormīre* 'sleep'). One would thus be forced to motivate *optāre* analogically, e. g. as a decompositional form (cf. *exoptāre*, *adoptāre*, *praeoptāre*) somehow influenced by the derived "perfective" type seen in a few forms like *assentāre* ← *sentīre* (: *sēnsus*), *adventāre* ← *venīre* (: *ventum*). Such an analogical account is not without its prob-

lems, which need not, however, be rehearsed: the main drawback is the undesirability of the extra analytical step that would be required if one begins with an "ideal" Narten-iterative **ōpīre*.

3.4. Finally, it should be noted that even if one accepts original Narten-inflection for this root (cf. n. 7 above), the absence of an "ideal" Narten-iterative **h_1ŏ́p-i̯e/o-* and the apparent presence of an iterative **$h_1$op-é̯ie/o-* of the standard type need not be considered surprising. The "ideal" Narten-iteratives and -causatives are themselves not terribly well attested, and Narten-roots not infrequently display iteratives or causatives made (in some cases no doubt at relatively late periods) according to patterns that were still at least faintly productive: thus the submerged or vestigial Narten-root **bher-* 'carry',[10] which is best attested as a plain thematic verb, shows no trace of an "ideal" **bhŏ́r-i̯e/o-*, as opposed to the normal iterative formation seen in Gk. φορέω 'carry (constantly, regularly)'; note similarly the Narten-intensive **u̯ōdʰ-é̯ie/o-* '(repeatedly) strike' (GAv. *vādāiiōiṯ*, Gk. ὠθέω), with normal iterative-intensive suffix **-é̯ie/o-* at least at the einzelsprachlich level, based on a Narten-present **u̯é̆dʰ-ti/*u̯édʰ-n̥ti* (García-Ramón 1998: 152, with further references).

4. In addition to the morphological difficulties raised by the presumed form **opiō* itself, as just detailed, it is not even certain that such a form can legitimately be extracted from the Festus gloss in question (cf. § 1.) — a point that was clear to Thurneysen, who labeled the conjecture *praedopiont* "sehr zweifelhaft" already in his dissertation (1879: 31 = 1991: 132).

4.1. To begin with, all manuscript variants show only forms with *-t-*.[11] Moreover, the prefix form *praed-* (which is an absolute *unicum* in all of Latin) is particularly difficult to justify, despite e. g. Leumann (1977: 561), who takes *praed-* as a "Nachbildung" after *prōd-* (itself secondarily formed after *red-*). One could accept without too much reservation, for example, a **praed-eō* or a **praed-igō* explained along these lines (cf. *red-eō, red-igō, prōd-eō, prōd-igō,* and even *antid-eō* [cf. **antid* in *antideā* and *postid/postideā*]), but the leap to a ***praed-opiō* is difficult to grant. While emendation is clearly required in order to resolve Festus' *"praedotiont"* in some satisfying way, there is nothing about the form itself that actually requires an interpretation *"praedopiont"*, beyond the meaning 'praeoptant' provided for the form, and a wish to find the missing base verb for *optāre*.

4.2. Indeed, other solutions are possible. In principle, the ideal solution would not only account for the two recalcitrant features of the transmitted text just mentioned (i. e. *-t-* and *praed-*), together with the meaning 'praeoptant', but should also take into account the third striking feature of the form, namely the 3 pl. ending *-ont* (vs. Class. Lat. *-unt*) – one of only three such forms attested outside of inscriptional Latin (not counting the relatively frequent forms in *-uont* and *-vont*, which have a secondary explanation), and all of them, as it happens, known from Festus. Indeed, the more famous of the other two is also found among the Carmen Saliare fragments, i. e. the celebrated 3 pl. *tremonti* (apparently still with primary *-i*) attested both in Festus and Terentianus Scaurus,[12] and the third is a form *nequinont* attributed to Livius

Andronicus.[13] The archaism of the ending *-ont* was evident to the Romans themselves, and it is telling that the two forms of this type cited as archaisms by Quintilian (1.4.16), namely *dederont* and *probaveront*, are typically met with in inscriptional formulae. The ending *-ont* is a feature that is inscriptionally attested mainly in the third and second centuries BCE;[14] similarly *nequinont* (Liv. Andr.: d. 204), and the still earlier *tremonti*.[15] Partly for this reason, and partly because the corruption clearly goes back to a very early stage of the transmission, it is appropriate to consider the transmitted *praedotiont* in terms of early Lat. inscriptional capitals, which form the basis of handwritten "capitalis" letter forms and the early cursive variants derived from them (for a convenient survey see e. g. Bischoff 1990: 54ff.).[16] In this case, one is immediately led to consider possible confusions between D and P, given, on the one hand, the common early Lat. "open P" (dominant in 3rd- and 2nd-century inscriptions, frequent well into the first century, and even found in early capitalis handwritten forms, as well as in early cursive) and the archaic "open D" (found inscriptionally mostly in 3rd-century or earlier texts, e. g. 39, 361, 2659, 2864, 2908, 2909),[17] and, on the other, early variants of closed P in which the rounded portion reaches almost to the bottom of the vertical, making P virtually indistinguishable from D (as in 2516a [early 2nd c.]; photograph in Degrassi 1965: No. 205). Under these circumstances, it is easy to conceive of an original PRAIPO- (to use the archaic form of the prefix) misread or miscopied, at an early stage of the transmission, as PRAIDO-; cf., indeed, Maurenbrecher's alternative emendation *praepotiont* (1894: 349), which finds some support in the existence of an early Lat. active variant *potiō* 'put in the power of' beside early and Class. Lat. *potior* 'be master of, obtain'.[18] As for the directly following three-stroke sequence -TI-: given, for example, the early variant of T with angled top-stroke (e. g. 2832a [Lap. Sat., ca. 500], 2833 [Castor-Pollux dedication, late 6th c.], 47 [3rd or early 2nd c.]), as well as the early variant of N in which the two right strokes occupy the upper half of the letter space (e. g. 5 APURFINEM [4th/3rd c.], 621 COLONIA and DEDUCUNDAE [2nd c.]), one can readily imagine an original -N- behind the transmitted sequence -TI-, both N and TI showing identical stroke sequences in terms of number and direction (see Bischoff 1990: 64). All of these considerations lead to the possibility of an original PRAIPONONT = Class. Lat. *praeponunt*; and *praepono* 'put before / in charge of, give priority to, prefer s.th. over s.th. else' is a virtual synonym, in at least part of its semantic range, of *praeopto* 'choose s.th. rather than s.th. else, prefer'. This relationship may also help explain the reason for the gloss itself (if it is not just an ancient misreading): the gloss would indicate that in the Carmen Saliare, *praeponont* has its relatively rare (but demonstrably old: Plt.+) Nebenbedeutung 'prefer' (*praeoptant*), rather than its Hauptbedeutung 'place (s.o., s.th.) at the head of'.[19]

5. Without insisting on the correctness of the above particular solution, it has at least been possible to demonstrate that the transmitted *praedotiont* is susceptible of interpretations (including that of Maurenbrecher) that do not require a form **opiō*; indeed, given the precarious nature of the presumed Lat. *praed-* (§4.1.), the emendation *praed-opiont* must be ranked among the least favored of possible solutions. Nor

does a Lat. **opiō*, in any case, have a compelling morphological basis (§§ 2.–3.). Since, moreover, Lat. *optāre* can be satisfactorily explained on the basis of a corresponding Umbrian *ē*-verb (§§ 2.2., 2.3.), we may conclude that Lat. **opiō*, despite the universal recourse to such an entity in both the standard handbooks and more modern treatments (n. 1 above), is a *vox nihili*.[20]

NOTES

[1] This account of Lat. *optāre/optiō* and **opiō* is pervasive in the standard handbooks and lexica of Latin (e. g. Lindsay 1894: 472, Leumann 1977: 366, Walde-Hofmann 2. 217 [s.v. *optiō*], Ernout-Meillet 464 [s. v. *optiō*], OLD 1260 [s. v. *optō*], TLL IX².824.81ff. [s. v. *optō*]) and Indo-European (e. g. Walde-Pokorny 1.176f., Pokorny 1959: 781, LIV 266), as well as in more recent treatments of individual forms (e. g. Rosén 1981: 160n4 and Gaide 1988: 209 on *optiō*) and form classes (e.g. García-Hernández 1985: 235, in a study of the Latin frequentatives).

[2] Lat. **opto-* < **opeto-* matching U. **upetu**, *upeter*: e. g. Buck 1928: 163 (§ 212.3b). For present purposes, it is unnecessary to enter into the difficult problem raised by the apparent lack of syncope in Umbrian forms like *upeter* (under an interpretation **opeto-*), on which see recently Katz 1998: 201f. n. 47.

[3] Ernout-Meillet 465.

[4] I owe the conception of U. **opē-* as an IE iterative formation to a suggestion of Michael Weiss (personal communication of Dec. 7, 1996). Here also perhaps Alb. *(j)ep* 'gives', cf. LIV 210. M. Kümmel (LIV 266) sets up a root **h₃ep-* 'wish', but this is a *multiplicatio entium* that accounts only for Lat. *praedopiont* (see further below) and the Lat./Umbr. *o*-grades.

[5] On this process see recently Nussbaum 1994: 178ff.

[6] In addition to third- and fourth-conjugation forms like *ūtī/ūsus, fodīre/fossus*, see Nussbaum loc. cit. on second-conjugation *docēre/doctus, lūgēre/lūctus*, and further (181n64) the iteratives *spondēre/spōnsus, tondēre/tōnsus*.

[7] Note the scriptio plena in Hitt. *ēpzi* and the (possible) lengthened grades in Lat. *coēpī* and Ved. *āpnóti*; for the analysis in terms of a Narten-present see Oettinger 1979: 88, Weiss 1993: 16. P. Schrijver (1991: 28f., following Mayrhofer EWAia I.167, cf. now also LIV 210f.) prefers, perhaps rightly, to explain the long vowel of Ved. *āpnóti* via a reduplicated perfect, and offers a similar explanation for the Latin and Hittite forms. For Lat. *coēpī*, however, note Jasanoff's recent remarks (1998: 306f.) on the possible Narten-associations of other Latin perfectum stems in *-ē-*, esp. *ēgī* and *lēgī*.

[8] In contrast: LÉCTUS, PAASTORES, SCRÍPTA (with I longa), etc. (Allen 1978: 70).

[9] Leumann 1977: 82, e. g. *onustus, venustus* etc. < **-os-to-, dupundī* (Lucil.) beside *pondō*.

[10] For a recent justification of the Narten-present background of **bher-*, see Jasanoff 1998: 305.

[11] With Lindsay's sigla: *praedotiont* Ald., *praedotiunt* ed. princ., *predotiom* W.

[12] Fest. 222.29 L, GLK VII.28 (Morel³ 2, 4.10 [pp. 4, 6]).

[13] ***Nequinont**, pro nequeunt ... Livius in Odissia* (Fest. 160.3 L), ***Nequinont** nequeunt* (P.F. 161.3 L); Morel³ 11 (p. 25).

[14] For Quintilian's *dederont* and *probaveront* (all inscriptional references hereafter are to CIL I²): e. g. DEDERONT 383, [D]EDERO 61, DEDRON 30, DEDROT 378, DEDRO 379, PROBAVE[R]O 22 (more usually abbreviated as "PROB").

[15] Other inscriptional -ONT forms (all 3rd/2nd c.): COSENTIONT 9 (Scip. elog.), COIRAVERONT 364, SONT 1529. (All references to dates herein are BCE.)

[16] For the chronology, note also, in the same set of glosses, ***polet pollet, quia nondum geminabant antiqui consonantis*** (Fest. 222.27 L, Morel[3] 4.8 [p. 6]); geminated spelling of consonants, an orthographic innovation conventionally attributed to Ennius (d. 169), does not begin to appear in inscriptions until the early second century.

[17] Even in texts with closed D, some early variants of open P, with right stroke extending very low, are easily confused with D: e. g. the open P of 614 (early 2nd c.) INPEIRATOR is extremely similar to the D of the immediately following DECREIVIT (see the photograph in Degrassi 1965: No. 396).

[18] Maurenbrecher's emendation is less attractive in other ways. While act. *potiō* is attested, there is no real trace of a ***praepotiō* (not strongly supported by *praepotēns* [Plt.+] 'very powerful', surely just an instance of the productive *prae-* that forms "intensive" adjectives: *praecalidus* 'very hot', *praeclārus* 'very clear/bright; brilliant', etc.). Act. *potiō*, moreover, is no doubt a secondary causativization of the inherited deponent *potior* (: RV *pátyate*), on which see Flobert 1975: 422; there is thus no strong reason to believe in a very early act. *praepotiont* that could be glossed by *praeoptant*. Still more problematic is Maurenbrecher's own understanding of the etymological background of his *praepotiont* (cf. *petō, impetus* etc.; but this is *obscurum per obscurius*, as *petō* lacks a clear etymology [cf. Schrijver 1991: 395]. Even if *petō* belongs, as often assumed, with **peth*$_1$- 'fly, fall', a **pot[h*$_1$*]-i̯e/o-* could not be aligned with any comparable form either in Latin or Indo-European).

[19] Somewhat similarly (and with the same prefix), in the same series of glosses: ***praeceptat in Saliari carmine est saepe praecipit*** (Fest. 222.21 L, Morel[3] 4.1 [p. 5]), specifying that the sense 'instruct' (Class. *praecipio*) was conveyed in the Carmen Saliare by a frequentative *praecepto*. Note further Maurenbrecher's observation concerning the frequency of prefixed verb forms in the Carm. Sal. glosses (1894: 327), among which preverbs in *p-* form the most prominent subgroup (in addition to *praeceptat* and *praedotiont*, also *promenervat, prospices, promeriom, perfines*, and indeed the possible instance of *prae* in tmesis in *pretet tremonti*).

[20] Still less satisfactory is the traditional assumption that Lat. **opiō* is also the source of *opīnor* 'believe, suppose'; I address this problem elsewhere (1999), in a paper that appears in a volume co-edited with my esteemed colleague Vyacheslav Ivanov, to whom this *opusculum* is offered with affection and with profound admiration.

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